

Ancient Greek and Absurdity

Aorist Cats and Dual Parrots

Pau Amaro Seoane

The Punctiliar Cat

The Aorist tense (from *a-oristos*, "without horizon") expresses a simple, undefined action in the past.

- The Imperfect: The cat *was knocking* the vase over (ongoing).
- The Perfect: The cat *has knocked* the vase over (and the owner is currently angry).
- The Aorist: The cat *knocked* the vase over. It happened. Boom.

The Sketch Element:

- A violently confused cat sits next to shattered porcelain.
- The cat did not "used to knock it over". It was a singular, absurd event.

The Grammatical Reality: *The Aorist cat takes no responsibility for the consequences.*

The Aorist Passive Participle

The *lytheis* (having-been-loosed) cat.

A passive event completed in the past.

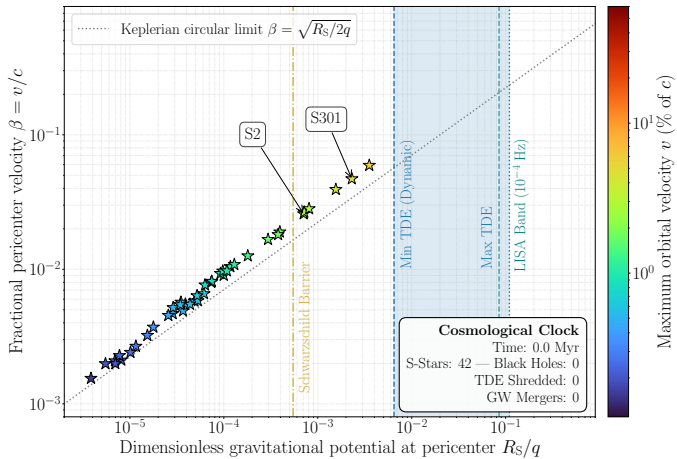
Dialogue Note

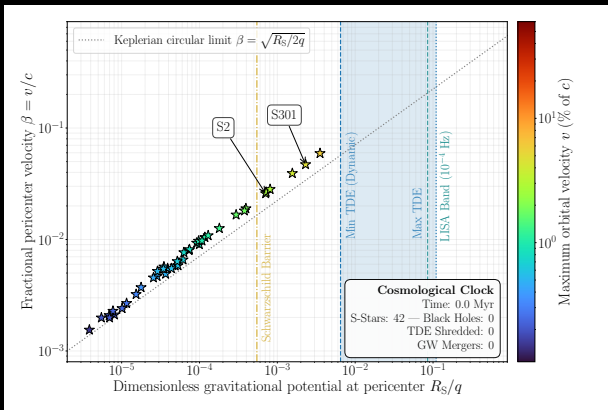
The Confused Cat Sketch:

"I wish to register a complaint about this feline!
It is a *having-been-confused* (Aorist Passive) cat!"

"No sir, it's just in a state of present continuous
bewilderment!"

Part II: The Dual Number and Deceased Avians





- Ancient Greek features Singular, Plural, and the rare **Dual** number.
- The Dual is used strictly for pairs (e.g., two eyes, two hands, two parrots).
- Customer: "I wish to return to *psittako* (these two parrots)."
- Shopkeeper: "They are resting! Both of them! A dual state of rest!"

Declining the Dead Parrots

In the second declension, the dual endings are famously sparse:

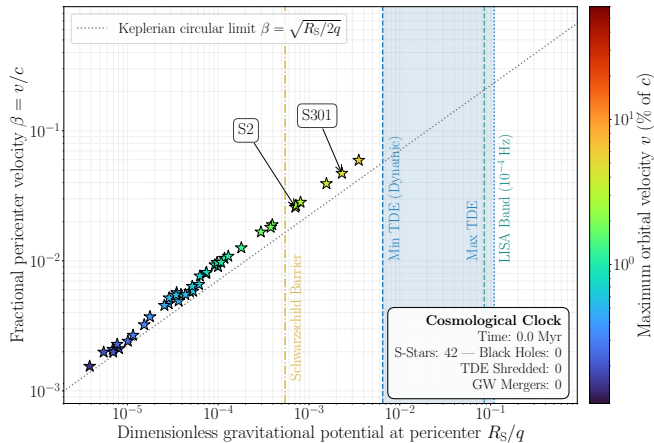
- Nominative/Accusative/Vocative: -o (e.g., *to psittako* - the two parrots).
- Genitive/Dative: -oin (e.g., *toin psittakoin* - of/to the two parrots).

The resulting sketch dialogue:

- Customer: "I nailed *to psittako* (the two parrots) to the perch!"
- Shopkeeper: "If you hadn't nailed them, *to psittako* would have muscled up to the bars and voom!"
- Customer: "Mate, *to psittako* are deceased! They have ceased to be!"

The final verdict: *The dual parrots have joined the choir invisible!*

Part III: The Optative of Wish



A video of a cat wishing for a fish: "Eithe ho ichthys pareie!" (Would that the fish were here!)